

I.G.W.C.

2026-01

Field Report

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Indiana Graduate Work
Coalition is a a member
labor union representin
graduate workers at Ind
University, Bloomington

Graduate workers at IU
rising cost of living,
deteriorating working
conditions, and funding
program cuts across the
university.

This is a *field report* on
conditions.

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Do you need a union? Take this quiz to find out!

Score 1 point for every question you answer "yes"

- ☐ Are you a graduate student?
- ☐ Do you eat?
- ☐ Can you eat tuition remission?
- ☐ Do you work in a lab?
- ☐ Do you work in a classroom?
- ☐ Do you work at IU at all?
- ☐ Have you ever wanted a fancy cheese from the fancy cheese section of Kroger?
- ☐ Do you travel for your research?
- ☐ Has your rent increased in the last few years?
- ☐ Do you live with roommates?
- ☐ Do you have kids or dependants?
- ☐ Do you want better healthcare?
- ☐ Do you want multiple years of secured funding from the university?
- ☐ Do you want funding for 12 months of the year?
- ☐ Do you want IU to be able to host the best faculty and resources?
- ☐ Do you think your research matters?
- ☐ Is your department potentially being merged?
- ☐ Do you want IU to be a good school?
- ☐ Do you want collective bargaining?
- ☐ Do you care about other graduate students?

SCORING:

If you scored between

0 and **20** points

***You need
a Union!***

Sign a Union Card!



indianagradworkers.org/card

Indiana Graduate Workers Coalition is a member-run labor union representing graduate workers at Indiana University, Bloomington.

Graduate workers at IU face a rising cost of living, deteriorating working conditions, and funding/program cuts across the university.

This is a *field report* on those conditions.

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Cost of Living in Bloomington is rising. Wages aren't (except after strikes).

It's nothing new that the cost of living is getting out of hand, but it is important to reiterate the role of the union in addressing the crisis. As of today, according to the MIT calculator, it takes \$43,605 annually for a single person. For people with a child to live, that number skyrockets to \$80,853. Meanwhile the graduate student stipend sits at \$24,000 or just 55% of the living wage (30% or less if you have children).

In 2022, stipends after paying student fees to the university were under \$14,000 with some students making around \$12,000 after fees. The IGWC strike shut down university classes for four weeks as we demanded a living wage and recognition. Though the strike ended without an official resolution or recognition, the impacts of worker power were clear. Before the beginning of the next semester, the university raised graduate stipends to \$22,000.

When announcing this rise, the university attributed it to the work of a task force and personal action taken by the Provost and President, completely omitting the role of the IGWC. Why would he or anyone else want to acknowledge where serious power lies? But it was clear that it was our pressure that forced the university's hand. Recognizing the inadequacy of the raise and the continued lack of recognition, IGWC went on a three day strike in the Spring of 2024. In each successive summer, the university responded by adding

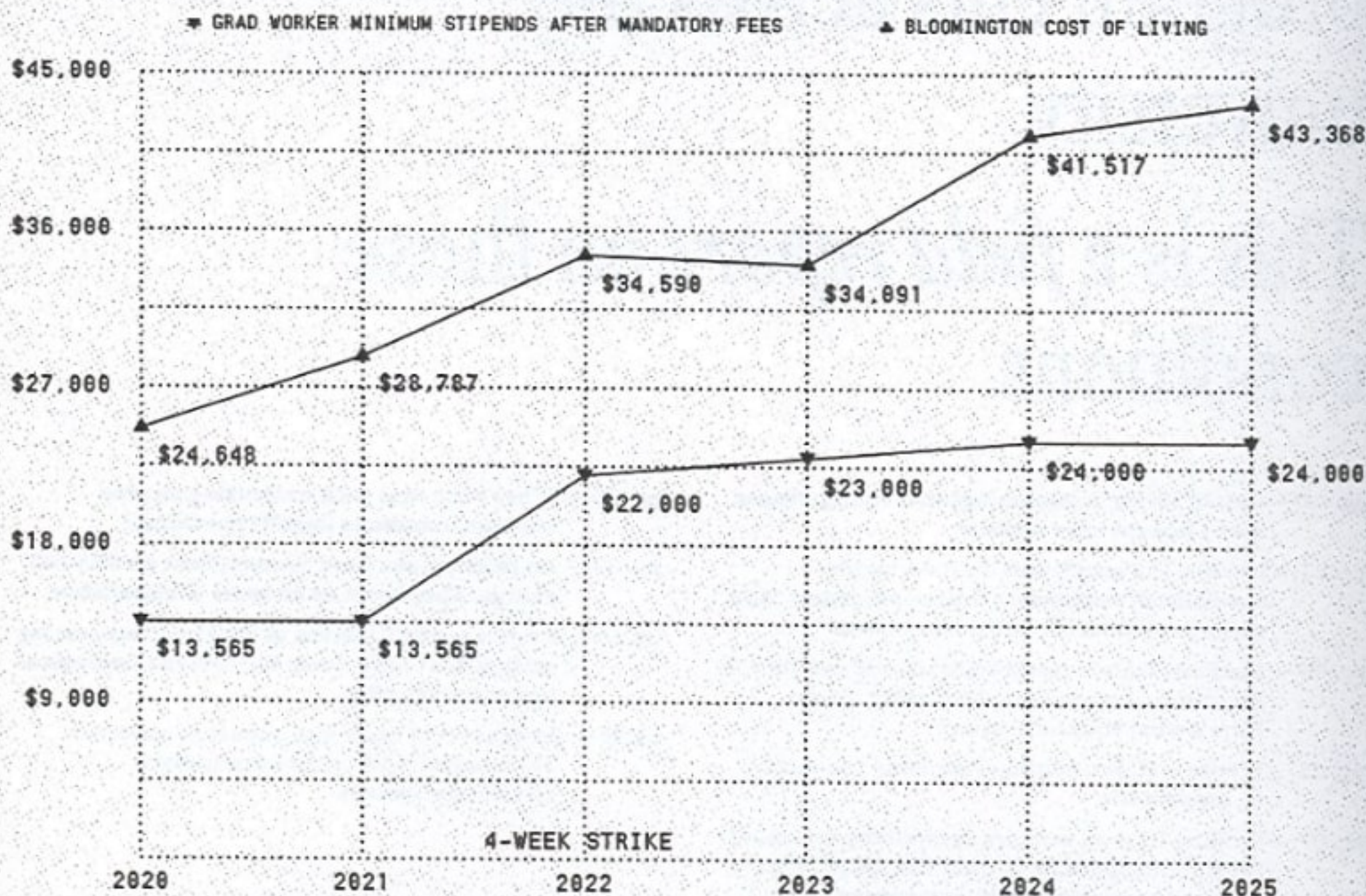
\$1000 to the minimum stipend, bringing us to today's minimum.

IU's cost of living crisis will continue to get worse based on trends in the last decade. Since 2021, when the cost of living was just \$28,787, the stipends covered just 54% of the cost of living in Bloomington, close to today's post-strike percentage of 55%.

To even keep pace with the dramatic increase in the cost of living, it took dramatic action from graduate workers to put the issue front and center. As the cost of living crisis intensifies, that kind of organizing is precisely what we need now. In just a decade, Bloomington's cost of living has increased from just \$17,139 by over 250%. Housing is one of the most important of all these. All indications point to this trend continuing.

The lessons from this are clear. IU has the resources to support their robust educational mission, but they choose not to. The only thing pushing them to maintain standards of graduate worker conditions is our continued militancy. It would of course be preferable to be a recognized union, and have a *de jure* seat at the table where these issues are decided. But until Indiana University decides to recognize us, our very survival relies on collective organizing.

● Bryce Greene, Informatics



Indiana University was built on highly-specialized, world-class degree programs. Now, those programs are being eliminated.

Indiana University Bloomington has historically been celebrated for its academic diversity, especially in the humanities. It enabled outlets for students, faculty, and staff to produce highly specialized academic research and education. These include niche departments and degree programs, the plurality of which coalesce to form a one-of-a-kind public institution of research and higher learning, often unmatched even by elite universities, and even lending IU Bloomington the label of a “public Ivy.” IU Bloomington awards more PhDs in the humanities annually than any other American university. IU is widely regarded for the level of Less Commonly Taught Languages offered, with rare and exceptional programs in Haitian Creole; Central Asian, Slavic, and African languages, and Chin, to offer some examples. This diversity of programs in language, literature, and culture put IU

Bloomington at the cutting edge of Area and Cultural Studies when these fields first came on the university scene in the mid-twentieth

century and has resulted in the range and persistence of the university’s cultural centers. IU Bloomington is a leading public institution in the number of monographs published by faculty. The breadth and depth of scholarship at IU Bloomington produce highly specialized expertise, particularly evident in the range of doctoral minors, while also offering all students rare opportunities to study widely beyond their majors through an exceptional array of courses and faculty. These offerings allow students to become both specialists and generalists in ways unavailable at most institutions. IU Bloomington may be the only university where one could study investigative journalism, Uyghur, and the history of alchemy in a single semester, all with world-class experts.

This situation is rapidly changing. Drastic degree cuts mandated by the 2025 Indiana House Budget Bill threaten both the university’s national standing and its core academic mission. The budget bill, which passed in July of 2025, places new criteria for productivity for each degree currently offered, threatening to cut programs that produced less than three doctoral, seven master’s, or fifteen bachelor’s degrees in the previous year. The result is the elimination or consolidation of 249 degree programs, nearly 19% of IU Bloomington’s offerings—a serious erosion of the university’s academic mission. The rare languages and niche humanities departments bear the

risk of elimination through cuts or mergers, but the bill also deeply impacts programs in the natural, applied, and social sciences, including professional degrees such as those in public health and education. The only schools untouched by cuts or mergers are the Kelley School of Business; the Maurer School of Law; and the Luddy School of Informatics, Computing, and Engineering. Even as these schools seem to survive the academic massacre at hand, their appeal to current and prospective students will rapidly decline without the rare opportunities for training available from the wider university, and will no doubt have their own legacies diminished as a result. The turn from an academic institution to that which overwhelmingly offers degrees coded as “professional” ignores the fact that academics are also professionals, pursuing valuable careers and performing real work. The inevitable loss of faculty,

staff, and graduate student positions that will result from these cuts and mergers, and the description of academic units as “unproductive” illustrate that these cuts are not just the result of a curse of anti-intellectualism but are also anti-labor: anti-intellectualism is anti-labor.

While the criteria for the elimination or consolidation of degree programs are being sold under the label of

“productivity,” this notion of productivity obfuscates much. It ignores the academic output of the departments and centers associated with the degrees—including monographs and journal articles published and edited by students, faculty, and staff; the workshops or conferences attended and organized; or the courses offered and the expanse of students this education reaches. Indeed, these outputs are eminently productive. Furthermore, at-risk degree programs are too small and not provided with the requisite resources to produce degrees at the demanded rate. Even the most prodigious departments of a certain size cannot be expected to be able to confer three doctorates annually, especially when the resources are inaccessible. Many of these departments navigate limited fellowships and Student Academic Appointments, which constrain cohort sizes, a pain compounded by limits on course offerings. The absence of competitive salaries for graduate students in particular, but also for staff and faculty, (to say nothing for the precarious nature of tenure at IU Bloomington generally) is a more substantial limit on the productivity of these departments as spaces to study and work than departmental specialization itself. Lastly, according to the Responsibility Center Management model of finance used at IU Bloomington, each academic unit is responsible for its own revenue. This further constrains smaller departments held to the same fiscal expectations as, say, a larger and more resourced department like the business school.

If I had a living wage, I would...

“Quit my second job.”

— A Graduate Worker in Education

The degree cuts and consolidations will change the nature and legacy of IUB as an academic institution. Established faculty will seek work at other schools. Prospective students, particularly students seeking a more specialized education, will not apply—particularly in departments where specializations have been consolidated. Fewer courses will be offered, resulting in fewer available student academic appointments for graduate students, leaving them to seek both tuition and living expenses elsewhere while still being expected to make progress on their degrees. Promises of teach-outs or preservation through consolidation will not prevent the erosion of departments or fields. Students will have reduced access to faculty and coursework, with no

assurance that their advisors will remain employed. Consolidation weakens disciplinary identity, dilutes unique departments, and renders special collections, research centers, and cultural centers vulnerable to elimination. Highly specialized degrees may no longer appear on diplomas, diminishing graduates' competitiveness on the job market and devaluing even existing alumni credentials. The cuts and consolidations premised on the guise of productivity, in fact, limit the productivity of students, faculty, and staff, perhaps even eliminating their job, and devaluing their labor and academic work.

● Ann Campbell, *History and Philosophy of Science and Medicine*

Students from a merged/ eliminated program in Education are nervous about their future. Here's what they have to say.

The Indiana Commission for Higher Education's list of merged, cut, and suspended programs has placed the PhD program in the Learning Sciences (LS) at the IU School of Education amongst those to be merged into another. As such, the department is currently working towards merging with the Instructional Systems Technology (IST) program. Although currently enrolled students will continue to follow the LS curriculum, it is likely that the program will eventually be restructured and collapsed into a stream of the IST program. For students of the LS PhD program, these changes are accompanied by worries about the immediate future of the department.

The Journal of LS characterizes the field as drawing from disciplines such as cognitive science, anthropology, and computer science and technology to build on theory of the processes of teaching and learning and to inform design of learning environments. Within IU, the program is unique for its rigorous

definitely theoretically heavier because we kind of think about thinking and learning about learning and kind of like the meta part of it," Passionfruit, a student in the LS PhD program, said.

Faculty across departments have made an effort to support LS students. "I do feel that our faculty have been transparent about merging with IST and we're looking at, you know, the new curriculum that is going to be put in place... I do feel like they were pretty affirming in the sense of like, you're fine, like you are going to be okay. And I appreciate that" Passionfruit said. Passionfruit continued to explain efforts from the IST faculty to further support students' transitions. "I feel like the IST faculty are making an effort to get to know LS students more, especially with the combining of the dossier class.... They were really nice and we were invited to different things. We got to meet Gamze. We got to meet Doctor Kale, we got to meet Dr. Kwon and stuff like that."

Despite these efforts, it can often feel like students and faculty alike are powerless to improve the department, especially given the other challenges that the department currently faces, such as limited faculty and broader policies restricting academic freedom. "We're all kind of just like in survival mode, whether you're looking for jobs or you're working on your diss[ertation] or you're finishing classes, like everyone's just trying to, like, get to the next part without it falling apart, it feels like we're always, like, jumping off of a stepping stone right before it sinks into the mud," Apple, another current LS PhD student, shared.

Anxieties around the merger are heightened by concerns of whether and how structures will be preserved for LS students. Current attempts are being made to consolidate aspects of the PhD degree with

If I had a living wage, I would...

"Pay off my debt."

— A Graduate Worker in Folklore

requirements in theory, design, and research methodology. In some cases, students simply do not envision their research goals and interests being related to the field of Instructional Systems Technology. "I look at knowledge systems and I feel like IST looks at the implementation of learning. I think that ours is

existing practices in IST, such as shifting the process for qualifying exams. However, these changes have not been seamless. "As it started playing out, there were all these bumps along the way that like, this doesn't make sense for learning sciences or this isn't a useful way to do this, because that's not how we write papers or whatever it is," Apple said. Further, differences in research structures also open the door for uncertainty around funding for new and incoming students. "Where's funding going to come from?" Apple asked, "Because we get funding from research projects. And if they don't do as many research projects or grants, you know, like what does that look like for future students?... It feels like they're telling us that they're merging programs when in reality they're dissolving everything that Learning Sciences is into what IST does."

This merger also impacts students' future plans and the kind of work they do. "The feedback that we get from our learning sciences faculty is very different from the feedback that we get for our IST faculty. And so the class itself is very helpful. But when there's only me and one other learning scientist in there, it's hard to get feedback for the learning sciences field because we are kind of getting IST feedback," Passionfruit explained. This merger also raises anxieties around the broader value of the degree. "If learning sciences as a discipline ceases to feel important, where do we find ourselves?... I feel like learning

sciences is already very niche," Apple said. These questions have implications for students and their job prospects after receiving their degrees, whether they seek to continue in academia or return to industry.

The IU Learning Sciences PhD program draws students from around the world with its renowned faculty, strong community, training in theory and research methodology, and access to IU's resources outside of the school of education, which support the interdisciplinary nature of the field and of students' interests. While the students worry that the merger will exacerbate current issues within the department and students in the LS department value preserving the study of learning sciences at IU, some remain optimistic about the future of a merged department. "Maybe the merge will just broaden our network. I don't know, I don't know what's going to happen. But yeah, I think learning sciences as a community is pretty resilient," Apple said.

● Anonymous

If I had a living wage, I would...

"Make my retirement plan something other than 'subsistence farming.'"

- A Graduate Worker in SPEA

Where is IU Foundation funneling the money to support IU? It isn't clear.

Recently, the IU Foundation has played an increasingly central role in reshaping the university's financial and institutional landscape. The Foundation traditionally functioned as a steward of gifts and endowments that supported a broad range of academic, cultural, and student life initiatives. Yet a series of decisions, administrative restructurings, and shifts in donor relations indicate a wider transformation in how the Foundation operates and how it aligns, both implicitly and explicitly, with the priorities of the current university administration. The emerging pattern raises serious questions about transparency, accountability, and the extent to which the Foundation continues to serve the diverse needs of the students and organizations it was created to support.

Recent reporting by the IDS reveals a series of troubling developments for the logistics of student life at IU. The collapse of the IU Funding Board's budgetary autonomy and the subsequent over-drafting of its accounts exposed deep failures of communication within university financial management. Graduate and undergraduate organizations that previously relied on a student-led, peer-reviewed body suddenly found themselves subject to a centralized, less accessible

process that left many groups without adequate financing and scant communication with the administration. Student leaders described repeated attempts to obtain basic financial information from the university, only to encounter silence or delayed responses. These events did not occur in isolation. They reflect a broader administrative pattern that appears to undermine student governance, reduce democratic oversight, and consolidate financial authority at levels increasingly removed from the student population. The result is an institution that is less free to assemble or organize. While there is a just amount of hand-wringing over the university's increasing hostility to free speech, this is an oft-overlooked facet of a broader culture of restraint and limitations on student life and culture.

Donor relations have also become strained. In 2025 the Foundation began imposing new restrictions on scholarship language that targeted support for marginalized groups, citing federal guidance that did not in fact require such changes. For months, donors found their scholarships frozen or quietly removed from public listings while Foundation staff offered inconsistent explanations. Some long-time benefactors, including alumni who established scholarships in

memory of loved ones, eventually withdrew their support entirely. These cases underscore how quickly philanthropic trust can erode when communication falters and when administrative interpretations of federal policy override donor intent and community needs. Donor funds also reflect an important democratic component of university life—one way in which alumni and contributors make lasting impacts which define campus life. Prominent alumnus Mark Cuban has raised similar concerns over his own request to fund the IDS's paper edition with a recent donation, a request which has been apparently ignored since the administration cited financial justifications for ending the paper.

At the same time, the Foundation's recent financial behavior must be understood within a wider institutional landscape that is becoming increasingly constrained by political pressure. State and federal cuts have already reduced IU's budget by one hundred million dollars, and Indiana University has entered a new round of reductions that will likely reshape hiring, research, and academic programming. The foundation plays a critical role in sustaining the university's capacity to weather these financial shocks which makes its recent choices even more consequential. The sale of more than fifty properties to the university signals a shift away from long-term revenue generation and toward immediate liquidation of assets, a strategy that raises questions about long-term planning and the financial independence of the institution. The sale encompassed more than fifty properties across Bloomington, including prominent commercial sites such as the Gables building that houses BuffaLouie's, a series of university office spaces along East 10th Street, multiple residential buildings near campus, and long-vacant parcels like the former site of Yogi's Bar and Grill, all of which the Foundation transferred to the university in a single transaction. These developments are happening at the same moment that donors, particularly those who support minority and LGBTQ students, have encountered new friction and uncertainty when attempting to make targeted contributions. The freezing of scholarships and the revision of donor agreements have weakened trust among some of the university's most committed (and prominent) alumni and supporters which reinforces the perception that the Foundation is aligning its policies with national political directives rather than the needs and values of the student body or university life.

Taken together, these developments should not be surprising. They reflect a pattern in which the upper administration has repeatedly acted outside or ahead of established channels of consultation with the students, staff, and faculty who actually create campus life. The erosion of the student-run Funding Board, the restrictions placed on targeted philanthropy for marginalized communities and the transfer of dozens of Foundation-owned properties into university control all point toward an institutional culture where authority is increasingly centralized and where decisions with major consequences for campus life are made with limited transparency. These shifts have already produced measurable strains. Student organizations have lost access to predictable funding, donors have expressed frustration and, in some cases, withdrawn support, and faculty have repeatedly raised

concerns about the administration's priorities. The most visible expression of this tension came in the recent votes of no confidence by several academic units, which followed the administration's mishandling of the Palestinian Solidarity protests and its punitive actions toward students and faculty. Those votes signaled a profound breakdown of trust in the administration's willingness to uphold shared governance, academic freedom, and clear lines of communication. As the university faces mounting financial pressures from state and federal cuts and navigates an increasingly complex landscape both, the combined actions of the administration and the Foundation suggest a future in which campus governance becomes less responsive to the constituencies it is meant to serve. Ultimately, this makes for a less culturally dynamic, financially stable and intellectually rich campus and deepens a long-extant divide between Indiana University's students, faculty and alumni and the university's trustees and administration.

These developments also help explain why the Indiana Graduate Workers Coalition has become a crucial institution for graduate student organization and advocacy. As the Foundation and upper administration consolidate their vision of campus life, graduate workers have increasingly found that the university's internal mechanisms are unable or unwilling to safeguard their long-term professional and economic interests. The IU Foundation's recent decisions do not reflect mere administrative turbulence. Rather, they reveal a broader institutional pattern that treats the labor of graduate instructors and researchers as a flexible budget line rather than as the foundation of the university's teaching and research mission. The same administrative opacity that produced the collapse of the Funding Board and the freezing of donor-supported scholarships has also shaped labor relations, where graduate workers confront rising costs of living, stagnant wages, inconsistent communication, and little evidence that the administration recognizes their contributions as vital to the university's financial future. These conditions have made collective action a practical necessity. In the absence of reliable institutional stewardship, the Graduate Workers' Union has emerged as one of the only organizational structures capable of articulating graduate student needs, demanding fair compensation, and holding the administration accountable. The union's growth is therefore neither an anomaly nor an adversarial escalation but a predictable outgrowth of a campus environment where transparency has eroded, trust has frayed, and the university's administrative and philanthropic arms have failed to demonstrate meaningful support for the workers whose labor sustains the institution and the students which ultimately carry the university's legacy forward.

● *Chris Bowers, History*

If I had a living wage, I would...

"Get my prescriptions without overdrawing my account."

— A Graduate Worker in History and Philosophy of Science

In 2022, striking IU grad workers delayed two of the most prestigious journals in their discipline. That solidarity reshaped their department.

Few academics outside IU know why the summer 2022 issues of the *Journal of American History* and the *American Historical Review*, two of the most important journals in the discipline of history, were several weeks late. Most assumed that the delays were due to the paper and printing shortages that had significantly impacted the publishing industry. At IU, however, the cause for the delays was abundantly clear: editorial assistants had joined the IGWC strike.

Striking the journals was a key part of the organizational strategy in the History Department in 2022—not just as a point of leverage, but as a way of building collective power and solidarity in preparation for the strike. Thinking about labor and leverage collaboratively with workers resulted in a strong union culture that persisted far beyond the strike itself.

The IGWC began its build-up to a strike in February 2022 after it became clear that IU administration would disregard their own unionization policy (HR-12-20) to avoid collective bargaining for graduate workers. Strike preparations focused on gathering strike pledges in instruction-heavy departments and finding ways to amplify the impact of the strike through media: alumni outreach, undergrad outreach, and attacks on IU's brand. Of the 2600 graduate workers across teaching, research, and editorial work, only 800 IGWC members who signed strike pledges were involved with teaching. Public pressure was intended to intensify the material impact of withholding labor.

The History Department, like many departments, was in no position to strike. The conditions in the department were disheartening. Though the department had over 100 students, only 30 were funded through teaching appointments, and those appointments only graded. No History student oversaw a discussion section, let alone a whole class. The IGWC emphasis on teaching, either leading discussion sections or whole courses, meant the work as graders in the History Department seemed less impactful despite grading more students. If the IGWC saw teaching labor as its main leverage over the university, that type of leverage didn't exist in the History Department. What was particularly daunting was that history students

were fractured. There were no social connections in the early cohorts, and intense drama in the later cohorts. History students had signed union cards, but were not united.

Worse, even enthusiastic union members had intense fears. The History Department was not well-connected to the Organizing Committee, and most had no sense of the IGWC strategy at all. Was the strike illegal? Would people be fired? Would it even work? Did it even matter if History participated since grad workers didn't have the same teaching responsibilities?

When one organizer called a history union meeting, half a dozen interested history students gathered in the back room of Soma to voice their anxieties. The organizer who called the meeting tried to answer these common questions, but didn't know much beyond basic information. Questions like "would people get fired" were simple to answer, but questions about the overarching strategy were more challenging.

In order to shift the meeting away from airing anxieties, we had to take a step back to fundamentals: a strike is about leveraging the labor of workers over the university. That labor is essential to the university—otherwise the university would not pay for it. Withholding that labor forces the university to reckon with workers collectively. The total value of that labor (measured in labor hours) is the leverage workers have. History might not have the same teaching leverage, but it might have other forms of leverage that could propel the strike to success. This step back to strike fundamentals

helped reframe the anxieties; the question was no longer *if* a strike could work, but *how to find leverage* over the university in the History Department.

Editorial labor looks more like lab work than teaching work. Students work fixed hours in the office, and are responsible for deliverables at set points in the academic year. They are typically overseen by a single faculty member (equivalent to a PI) who may or may not have tenure. Graduate workers in both labs and journals do mundane labor. At journals, graduate workers proofread and factcheck, but do not copyedit; they sort books and contact readers, but do not make editorial decisions. Despite this, their labor was too specialized to easily scab. To have other workers pick up (scab) extra editorial or lab work would require knowledge that even the full time staff might not know. Like labs, journal

If I had a living wage, I would...

"Buy better food."

— A Graduate Worker in Informatics

graduate positions are only partially funded through IU and rely on external funding like grants, academic org funding, and partnerships. IU benefits from labs and journals by taking a cut of that external funding and more abstractly in the prestige from the journal/lab's output and standing in the field.

If I had a living wage, I would...

“Finally get a car 🥰.”

– A Graduate Worker in Physics

Editorial work comprised a significant portion of graduate labor in the department—roughly 1/3 of graduate workers in history received funding from the *Journal of American History* (5 grad workers) or the *American Historical Review* (6 graduate workers). The editorial work was structured such that even 2 or 3 people on strike would drastically increase work for those who chose to scab. At the *Journal of American History*, workers estimated that just 2 striking workers would mean the June issue could be delayed 1 month, and the September issue would have to be completely rescheduled. The role of graduate students at two key points in the production process (factchecking and proofreading) meant that even a small labor action would have dramatic impacts.

History organizers scheduled meetings with the history students at the journal and offered a simple question: how do you want to engage with the strike? The IGWC was not focused on editorial labor, since it constituted such a small portion of total graduate labor at IU, but an editorial strike would intensify the teaching strike. Organizers laid out the possible risks, the numbers and goals, and the overall strategy both in the department and the IGWC, but emphasized that whatever editorial workers did, they should do it together.

Workers debated what labor they would withhold, and the merits of withholding their labor at all. The conversation at the *American Historical Review* was far more intense, since the journal had announced days before that it would leave IU and phase out its

graduate and faculty staff over the next 2 years. “Fuck them,” the managing editorial graduate worker said, “I’m not going to do anything for them. You all can try to work if you want, but I’m not giving out tasks.” Other workers agreed. The *American Historical Review*, the most important journal in the discipline of history, was strike-ready in a 15 minute conversation. The *Journal of American History* was more nuanced, and workers thought about which tasks constituted the bulk of the labor. The consensus was that the workers should strike, but should try to avoid delaying production for the September Issue. Grad workers would not proofread or process the June issue for the duration of the strike, but would not try to actively delay the future issues until it was clear the strike would last into September.

The journals were the momentum shift history organizers needed to activate the rest of the department. Using the strategy of group meetings, history organizers created a department-wide Discord server and used that to build richer social connections. The passion from workers at *American Historical Review* galvanized the department; if the *American Historical Review* was going out, why shouldn’t graders? When the IGWC launched its strike in April 2022, the two biggest journals in the discipline of history struck too.

The strike preparations galvanized the department. History was not ready to strike: workers were scared, alienated, and uncertain whether a strike was even possible. If workers had been asked if they wanted to strike, they would have overwhelmingly said “no.” There was no sense of solidarity between workers in the History Department to feel safe striking. What produced that solidarity was collective strategizing at the department level. This meant that workers and organizers were able to feel engaged with the union more broadly. What resulted was a strong department culture that persists far beyond the strike itself.

The strike was mobilizing because it was daunting. It made a material impact on the university, and when workers were able to engage with that, what was once a terrifying prospect became a transformative experience of collective action. Rather than give into the fears that history students had, the strike helped workers in history to reflect on the university and their position in it.

● Eli Beaton, History

What’s the deal with unionizing as grad workers in Indiana (legally speaking)?

Indiana Code (IC) 4-15-17 contains the laws concerning public-sector unions, currently affecting 32,075 state employees.¹ In summary, without a change from the Indiana General Assembly, the state cannot recognize or bargain with unions. Although state employees can organize (IC 4-15-17-6), they cannot threaten a work-stoppage without incurring a Class C infraction, which has a maximum penalty of a \$500 fine. Exemptions to IC 4-15-17 include the Indiana State Police, local entities like public schools (IC 3-5-2.1-79),

and educational institutions like Indiana University which are not defined as the “state” (IC 21-7-3-32).

Unlike public schools, IU does not have a labor relations board. Instead, unions are governed by IU policy HR-12-20. IU currently recognizes three American Federation of State, County and Municipal Employees (AFSCME) locals, 832, 1477, and 1477-01; and one Communications Workers of America (CWA) local, 4818. At most, these unions can make “recommendations” to

the Board of Trustees once every three years regarding policy, and annually regarding wages (HR-12-20§4(b)(4)). The "agreements" resulting from these recommendations make clear the legally-weakened status of Indiana's public-sector workforce.

Collective bargaining is the cornerstone of union politics. Bargaining allows employees to deliberate their needs directly with their employer. Public-sector employees, including IU staff, have suffered from legal precedents preventing them from sharing their private-sector counterparts' bargaining right: Section 8(a)(5) of the National Labor Relations Act (NLRA). The Boston Police Strike of 1919 demonized public-sector unions up until 1959, when Wisconsin Governor Gaylord Nelson authored the first law in America guaranteeing state employees the right to bargain: Wisconsin Statutes Section 111.70. Indiana would not pass equivalent legislation until 1975, with the Public Employee Labor Relations Act (PELRA). PELRA was immediately declared unconstitutional by the Indiana Supreme Court, a ruling used in 1981 by the Indiana Court of Appeals (Third District) during *Michigan City Area Schools v. Siddall*. *Siddall* determined that state employers, like IU, do not have to recognize their employees' unions, they cannot be compelled to bargain with unions, and even if they decided to bargain—they would be restricted in doing so. It was not until 1990 that Indiana's public-sector saw recognition, when Governor Evan Bayh gave state employees bargaining rights by executive order. This order continued as a gubernatorial tradition until 2005 when Governor Mitch Daniels signed Executive Order 05-14, revoking the bargaining rights of 25,000 workers. The direct result of Order 05-14 was the loss of thousands of government jobs and a state-wide pay-freeze during the 2008 recession. Although state employees can organize, without a statute protecting their bargaining rights, there is little hope of established unions achieving more power than the current Governor's benevolence allows.

The public-sector's lack of bargaining-power is a failure for labor relations. The century-old model of "business unionism" adopted by organizations like AFSCME and CWA accomplishes little under *Siddall* and Governor Braun, funneling employee voices into third-party "recommendations". The weakness of this model is its lack of employee-control. Employers use business unions to create long waiting periods and "no-strike" clauses that benefit

them by achieving all four "D's" of union-busting strategy: divide, delay, distract, and demoralize. Indiana University is responding to this spiritual union-busting with a new wave of "solidarity unionism". Solidarity unions avoid legal blockade through many observable methods. "Shopfloor committees", like the Indiana Graduate Workers Coalition (IGWC), are one such method. In shopfloor committees employees elect their coworkers to act as delegates, who then make demands on their behalf. The 2021-2024 IGWC strikewave is a perfect example of how these committees secure bargaining-power. Although HR-12-20 holds a campus-wide no-strike clause, IU students are not beholden to the policy until IU considers them employees. Under HR-12-20, and with *Siddall* as precedent, recognized unions cannot compel IU to make bargaining agreements and incur consequences for countering policy. So, as an un-recognized committee of employees, the IGWC can make demands without facing recrimination. Finally, since the penalties in IC-4-15-17 only apply to those in public office, students are legally free to organize: strikes included. The IGWC has successfully met students' demands since 2019, using strike-action, demonstrations, pickets, and information campaigns without firing or legal consequence. Here, the goal of solidarity tactics is not to win concessions, rather solidarity encourages the truest form of collective bargaining: direct deliberation with one's employer. Recognition status sacrifices this, but it does not make solidarity tactics impossible. Recognized union locals can bargain using parallel organizations, like public school workers do with Red for Ed. The desire for bargaining-power is surging across the United States, and looking for an outlet. By communicating with and learning alongside our co-workers, the policies making the situation appear difficult can be overcome by new strategies avoiding them altogether.

● Wyatt Fritz, IWW

If I had a living wage, I would...

"Is there a charming way to say:
not being one surprise away from
financial ruin?"

- A Graduate Worker in SOAD

An
Anonymous Grad Student beat
an SEA 202 charge. They see it
as an issue of class/labor.

We've all heard the discourse on academic freedom surrounding SEA 202, Indiana's law regulating

what instructors can say in the classroom, and the political complaints instructors have faced in its wake.

But far too little has been said about what this law means for exploited graduate workers, our job stability, and our labor rights.

I am writing anonymously from the perspective of a graduate worker who faced a provably false complaint from a student, which has since, thankfully, been resolved. When I received my complaint, I gave my account of events and then waited for an update, knowing that one of three possible outcomes would occur. Most likely, the case would be informally resolved and dropped. Another possibility would be a formal investigation that was not pursued, leaving both accounts in my file. In the worst case, the least likely, but no less terrifying for it, the university would pursue the complaint, or send it to the state, which could result in suspension or firing/expulsion.

Professors make above a living wage. Graduate students do not, not even close. We cannot afford suspension, let alone termination. We have no savings. If we lose our jobs, we cannot make rent next month or pay for food. Further, professors have a better shot at winning these cases, drawing on their professional reputations and colleagues with similar reputations, while graduate students do not have that kind of social capital or institutional sway. We would have to rely on *pro bono* legal representation, and hope for the best. And of course, the free student legal support is not an option for cases involving the university itself. Finally, such cases threaten future job prospects, derailing one's chances in an already extremely unstable academic job market.

Consequently, professors can focus on the free speech issues such complaints pose in their classrooms and lives, while graduate students face a particular class-based effect of these complaints—it is not our free speech, but our material livelihood that is on the line. Has the university made a single move to protect graduate workers from this threat to our employment and this infringement of our rights as workers? No. The administration acts as if it is not happening. Something they can get away with because we are not supposed to discuss cases, even upon resolution. Nobody is tracking how many graduate workers are facing threats to our employment based on provably false, politically motivated complaints. Because we cannot reach out to our peers, departments, or our union for support, aside from a handful of need-to-know people, we are left to worry about our continued employment in near-isolation.

This silence serves to divide us, to force us into an even weaker position—that of facing down the bureaucratic goliath as individual laborers rather than banding together, speaking openly about the threats to our jobs posed by the combination of censorship laws and an institution that does not see us as workers, so does not prioritize our specific concerns as underpaid laborers in a particularly unstable position due to our relative lack of power.

From one grad worker to another: sign a union card, for all of us.

● Anonymous

A letter to the IU Board of Trustees: Supporting science isn't hard. Keep the Indiana Geological Water Survey labs.

IU Administration plans to move the Indiana Geological and Water Survey out of the east wing of the Geology Building and into an off-campus, IU-owned building with no laboratory space by the end of the year. At this time, it is likely that we will be expected to fund the move and subsequent renovations. These changes will greatly limit our ability to fulfill grant obligations, provide student research and job experiences, and effectively accomplish our responsibilities under state statute. Indiana Code 21-47-2 establishes the IGWS as part of Indiana University, and it is under the Board of Trustees to direct and control the work of discovering, developing, and preserving the water, mineral, and energy resources of Indiana.

If I had a living wage, I would...

"Afford in-unit laundry."

— A Graduate Worker in History

Dear IU Board of Trustees,

I'd like to raise concerns for the recent plans to move the Indiana Geological Water Survey (IGWS) out of the Geology Building on Bloomington's campus and to a non-laboratory building off campus.

I am a PhD student in the department of Earth and Atmospheric Sciences (EAS). Their proximity to my department has led to close collaborative ties for many, and for me specifically, research in water resources and energy use. Their labs have been a rich resource for my work, and their technical expertise has helped me on numerous occasions.

I speak from a modicum of experience with this grievance, as I am a member of one of the EAS labs in Multidisciplinary Science Building II whose space IU is also sacrificing for a different department. These moves make us dismantle and reassemble intricate equipment, compact and squeeze our already-tight labs, and waste valuable research time just getting back on our feet. It will be a huge setback for the Survey. How

can Indiana know how to properly govern their resources if they inhibit those researching them?

Your administration continues to shuffle research spaces and in doing so leaves us with the burden of keeping up with the fast pace and high standards of scientific research in unstable conditions. In the case of the IGWS, it is even more outrageous to force these same researchers to foot the bill for space renovations necessary to just continue doing their jobs right.

Program cuts don't just impact IU students. These cuts impact the entire Indiana Healthcare system.

As someone with a hereditary cancer syndrome, I've been going to the dermatologist for yearly screenings since middle school. Upon moving to Bloomington, I was surprised to learn IU Health Dermatology's wait time new patients is longer than a year. Worse, this is standard for IU Health. Patients often wait six months or more to see a doctor and whole regions of the state lack specialists. This points to the massive healthcare worker shortage in Indiana, which is only getting worse. According to data from the Cicero Institute, Indiana's physician-to-patient ratio is 23% below the national average, and 71 counties (there are only 92 total) are considered "health professional shortage areas." Monroe County is not one of them. In other words, it's even worse elsewhere.

What does this have to do with IU Bloomington and its department cuts?

Both the Indiana state government and IU Administration have framed the cuts to less "popular" departments as a matter of efficiency. For one, this disavows the instrumental labor these departments perform in the service of general education or career-preparatory courses. But some cuts, like those to IU's microbiology and anatomy departments do nothing but exacerbate an ongoing healthcare worker shortage, not to mention the precarious situation in rural healthcare, due to Medicaid cuts.

To non-scientists, these two departments might not seem significant. But both are necessary for training future healthcare workers, including nurses, doctors, medical research scientists, and pathologists. And while basic classes and existing tenure lines can be transferred to larger departments in the short term, shuttering these home departments risks IU's long-term capacity to hire and retain experts in these fields. Would you want to work at a university who recently

When I first joined IUB two years ago, I was excited to be a part of this university. Now, though I still cannot understand why IU feels so comfortable in sacrificing the spaces and research of its earth scientists, it is clear that you don't value us.

Actions like this ensure that current students such as myself will not look back at the university with favor once we are gladly gone.

● Janelle Wittmer, Earth and Atmospheric Sciences, whose words do not necessarily reflect the opinion of her lab or her employer.

terminated the department where your specialty was housed? As professors retire or move on, there will be fewer experts available to teach courses, fewer mentors for students, fewer research labs, and less opportunity for students to explore, let alone pursue, careers in

these fields. In short, eliminating these key health science programs poses an enormous threat to healthcare access across Indiana, which will affect workers and families for decades to come.

This is especially

concerning given that IU's own medical and nursing schools admit majority in-state students (many of whom attend IU for undergraduate study). 81% of IU School of Medicine (IUM)'s 2024 incoming class came from Indiana, and, per IUM's residency placement report, more than a quarter of their 2025 graduates pursued residency at IUM or IU Health, "demonstrating that the school is fulfilling its commitment to prepare the next generation of physicians who will care for Hoosiers." That being said, only half of our residents continue to practice in Indiana as attending physicians. The state is hemorrhaging doctors. If IU cared about Hoosiers, it would commit everything it could to protecting small science departments. These doorways to careers in medicine are vital for countering this exodus.

As for nursing, IU enrolls nearly an order of magnitude more students in its bachelors of nursing science degree (which relies on the availability of anatomical education at the college level) than in its graduate level nursing programs. Currently, IU's nursing school is ranked highest in the state, and 95% of its graduates are licensed to practice here in Indiana. Cutting departments that offer pre-nursing coursework therefore significantly undermines the future stability of the health workforce across the state. So much of

If I had a living wage, I would...

"Go on vacation for once."

— A Graduate Worker in Gender Studies

medical care is made possible by nurses. From emergency triage to inpatient medication and care management, nurses do most of the clinical and patient care work on which we rely.

But it goes much further than that; according to the 2023 Annual Report of the State of Indiana's Health Workforce, advanced practice RNs make up a third of our primary care providers. But the Trump administration has proposed curtailing loan opportunities for nursing students, a move which would make it impossible for many prospective nurses to pursue advanced degrees (more than 200 nurses graduated from IU's nursing doctoral and masters' degrees in 2024-5). Nursing is already under threat from the federal government, yet the state and the university

are willingly abetting that threat by "complying in advance."

Other universities in the state are creating additional programs, not trashing everything they can and hoping for the best. The University of Indianapolis introduced a new adult/gerontology primary care nurse-practitioner master's program explicitly to alleviate this problem.

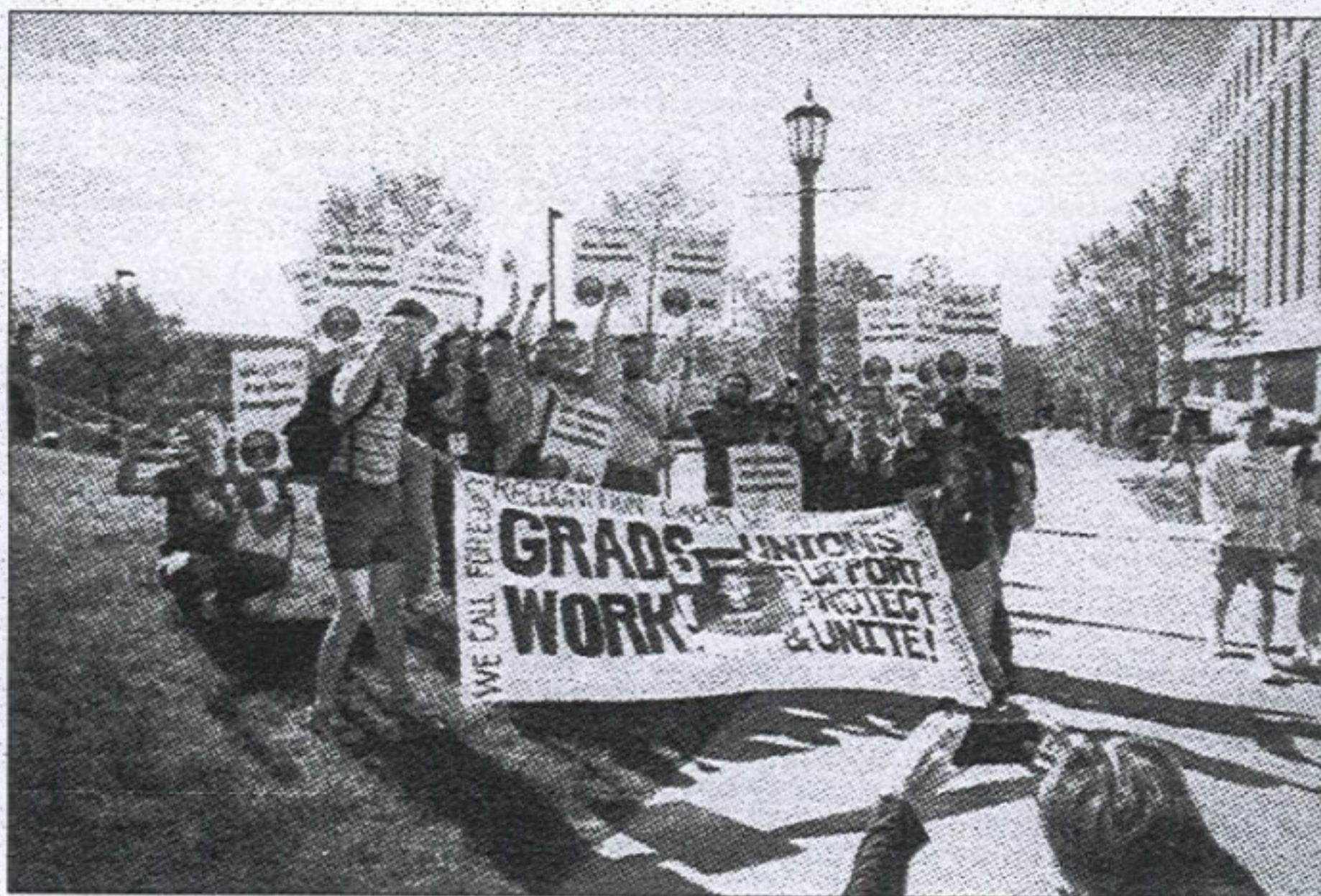
The threats to pre-med and pre-nursing tracks at IU are eroding the stability of the state's health infrastructure, and, by extension, diminishing the quality of life, health, and wellness in Indiana. Reversing these cuts would be one step toward supporting our healthcare workers and community's they serve.

● *Sasha Weiss, American Studies*

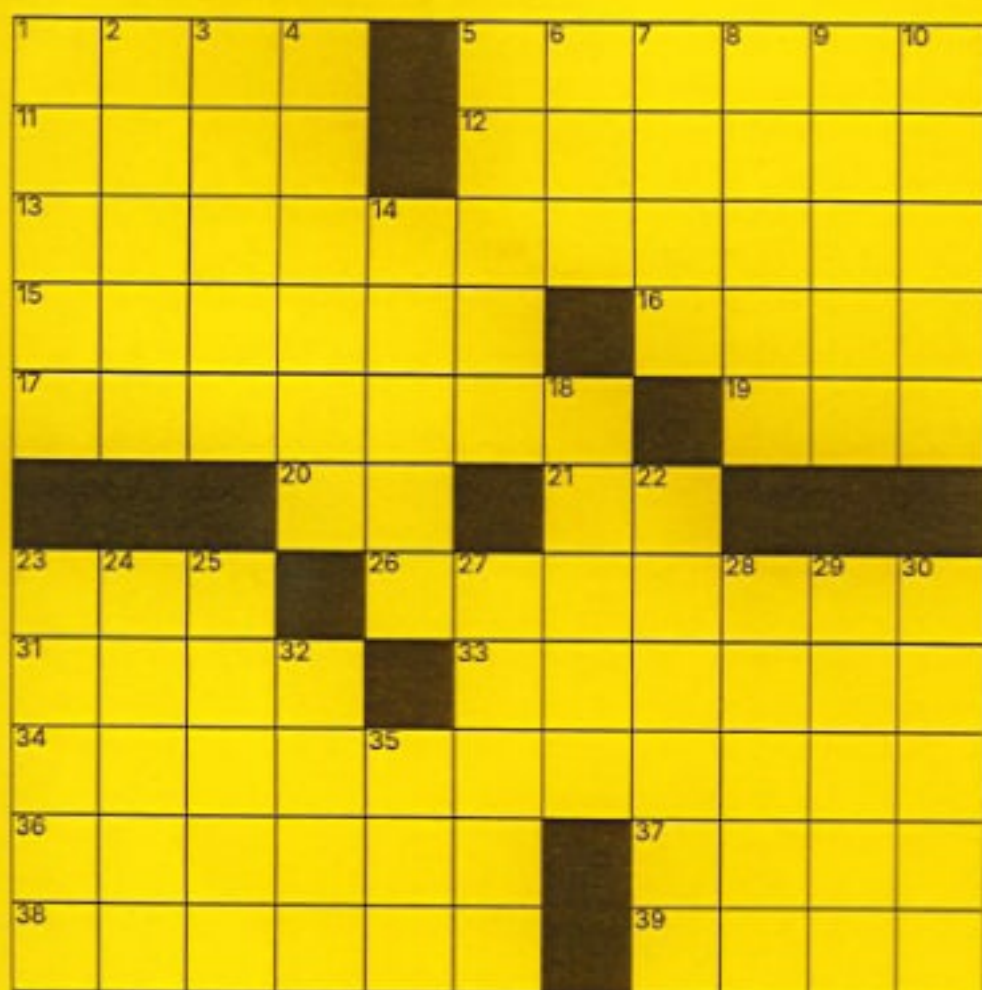
If I had a living wage, I would...

"Be able to send more money home for my family."

- A Graduate Worker in Biology



Solidarity forever.



ACROSS

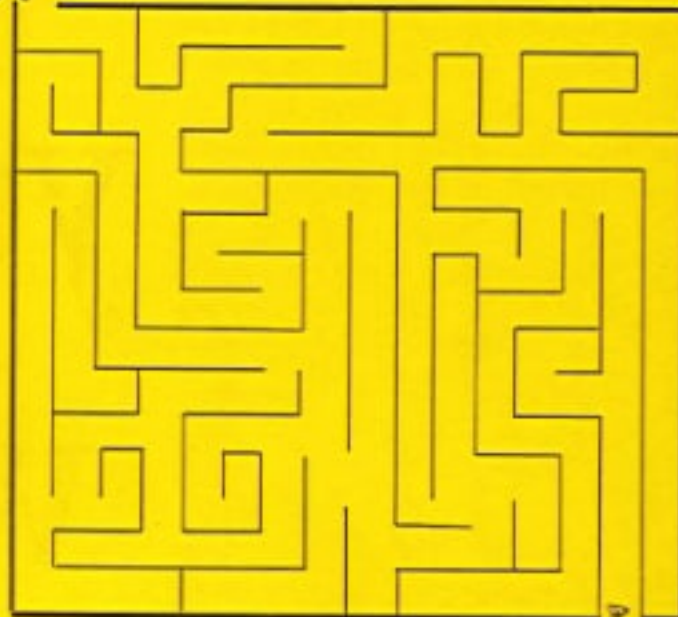
- 1 Worker-rights org.
 5 Hairdressers' hangouts
 11 Farewell, in Florence
 12 Ark's landing spot
 13 IGWC's demand for \$43k/year in Bloomington
 15 R&B musician formerly in a romantic entanglement with Jada Pinkett Smith
 16 IU dept. teaching Russian, Ukrainian, Bosnian/Croatian/Serbian, etc.
 17 "Burnt" pigments
 19 Graduate student workload unit abbr.
 20 Poet cummings
 21 IU Luddy School dept.
 23 Friend
 26 IU administrator who received a 93.1% no confidence vote from BFC
 31 "Got two fives for ___?"
 33 1954 Faulkner novel
 34 IGWC's demand for IU to formally acknowledge the union's rights for collective bargaining
 36 Pageant crowns
 37 Sephora competitor
 38 IGWC action that resulted in 3D
 39 Sodium laureth sulfate, in brief

DOWN

- 1 Indiana Hoosiers D1 participation Assocs.
 2 Actress Palmer or Soprano Lehmann
 3 a 46% increase for SAA stipends, from \$15,00 to \$22,000
 4 Cow, say
 5 Yemen's capital
 6 Sra. Peron's homeland
 7 Legislative output
 8 FLORA anagram
 9 Pester persistently
 10 IU Law professor Sanders
 14 "Autumn ___ York"
 18 Nebula Award genre
 22 visa ___ revoked for international graduate workers
 23 Components
 24 Absorbed a loss
 25 '70s Renault with a pseudo-French name
 27 Medieval trade group
 28 Short-term govt. security
 29 grilled corn street food topped with creme, chili powder, and cotija
 30 99 Luftballons singer, pluralized
 32 Sushi wrap sheet
 35 Goody stuff seen on Nickelodeon



Can YOU help admin find the money they owe us?



Want to join the union?

Fill out this union card and deliver it to a department organizer, or in-person at our weekly organizing meetings!

Every Wednesday, 5pm, 719 E 7th St

See upcoming events and meetings at our website: igwc.net

I hereby request and accept membership in the Indiana Graduate Workers Coalition (IGWC).

I authorize the IGWC to represent me and negotiate on my behalf all wages, benefits, and working conditions for SAA positions as the exclusive bargaining representative of graduate employees at IU.

FIRST NAME: _____ LAST NAME: _____

IU EMAIL: _____ NON-IU EMAIL: _____

PHONE: (_____) _____-_____ RECEIVE IMPORTANT TEXTS: []

DEPARTMENT ENROLLED: _____ YEAR ENROLLED: _____

CONTRACT TYPE 2025:

[] Instructional SAA [] Research SAA [] Graduate Assistant SAA
 [] Fellowship [] Hourly [] Not Employed by IU

I WANT TO GET INVOLVED WITH THE IGWC: []

I.G.W.C.

INDIANA GRADUATE WORKERS COALITION

Our University

indianagradworkers.org
 Meetings Wednesdays 5pm, 719 E 7th St



What would
you do
with a
living wage?